

Who Am I with AI? Occupational identity crafting in human-AI workplaces

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ABSTRACT

This study introduces the concept of occupational identity crafting, delineating its core dimensions—role, task, and skill crafting—as a proactive response to artificial intelligence (AI)-induced changes in the workplace. Using two pre-registered studies, we examine the impact of AI identity (assistant, partner, and leader) on employees' occupational identity crafting. Our findings show that with AI framed as a leader, employees experience enhanced role, task, and skill crafting, although the rate of role crafting tends to decelerate (Study 1). Additionally, drawing on the threat–opportunity framework, we explored the moderating role of human–AI relationship cognition (Study 2). The results indicate that the positive effect of AI framed as a leader on occupational identity crafting is stronger among participants with augmentation cognition, whereas substitution cognition does not exert a significant moderating effect. By conceptualizing and empirically validating occupational identity crafting, this study advances the theoretical understanding of employee adaptation to AI identities and provides practical guidance for managing human–AI collaboration.

With the rapid advancement of machine learning, algorithmic reasoning, and large language models, artificial intelligence (AI) is undergoing a profound transformation in organizational contexts. No longer confined to a passive assistive role, AI is increasingly functioning as a collaborative partner and, in some cases, an autonomous decision-maker (Jago et al., 2024; Lei and Rau, 2021; Murphy and Kreiner, 2020). This shift is redefining the structure and dynamics of work by redistributing responsibilities, automating core functions, and altering how decisions are made (Anthony et al., 2023; Parker and Grote, 2022). As a result, employees are no longer only adjusting their tasks. They are compelled to reevaluate and reconstruct their occupational identity, namely, how they perceive their professional value, purpose, and self-definition in the workplace.

Occupational identity extends beyond assigned roles or job descriptions; it encompasses employees' subjective understanding of “who they are” at work and the meaning they attach to their professional contributions (Alvesson and Willmott, 2002; Pratt et al., 2006). When AI increasingly assumes responsibilities once held by human professionals, such as diagnosing illnesses (Perez et al., 2024), making strategic recommendations (Keding & Meissner, 2021), or managing workflows (Black & van Esch, 2020), employees may experience a loss of clarity regarding their unique contributions. This disruption often leads to

psychological tension and identity uncertainty, as individuals question their relevance and value in an AI-mediated work environment.

In response to such disruptions, employees are not merely passive recipients of technological change. They engage in occupational identity crafting—a proactive process of redefining their roles, reconfiguring tasks, and developing new capabilities to restore coherence and meaning in their professional identity. While previous research has extensively examined occupational identity (Nelson and Irwin, 2014; Perez et al., 2024; Pratt et al., 2006), a systematic explanation of how employees actively engage in occupational identity crafting—specifically, the dimensions and behaviors through which individuals reconstruct their occupational self-concept—remains unexplored. The job crafting literature has provided valuable perspectives on how employees proactively adjust their job characteristics, typically defined as the tasks they perform, the relationships they cultivate, and the cognitions through which they frame their work (Lu et al., 2025; Song et al., 2022; Wrzesniewski and Dutton, 2001). These adjustments primarily reflect changes in what employees do and how they do it in terms of their work. By contrast, occupational identity crafting extends beyond the redesign of job characteristics to the reconstruction of who employees perceive themselves to be in relation to their work. This distinction highlights an important gap in the literature: although we know much about how

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employees reshape job content, we know very little about how they reconfigure their occupational self-concept in response to new workplace conditions. Furthermore, it remains unclear how employees interpret and respond to different forms of AI presence—from assistant to partner to leader—and how these interpretations shape their occupational identity crafting.

To bridge these gaps, we develop a multidimensional model of occupational identity crafting based on identity work theory, comprising role crafting (identity claiming), task crafting (identity expression), skill crafting (identity development), and explore the extent to which different AI identities (assistant, partner, and leader) influence these dimensions. Extending this and drawing on the threat–opportunity framework (Dutton & Jackson, 1987), we propose that employees’ cognition of AI—as either an enabler of human potential or a threat of substitution—critically moderates their occupational identity crafting behaviors. Specifically, when AI is positioned as an assistant, partner, or leader, employees with augmentation cognition are more likely to proactively engage in role, task, and skill crafting, whereas those with substitution cognition are more prone to identity erosion and disengagement. Through this lens, our study highlights the cognitive boundary conditions that determine when AI identity influences the reconstruction of occupational self-concept.

The primary contributions of this study are as follows. First, this paper defines occupational identity crafting through three key dimensions: role, task, and skill crafting. We offer a structured framework for assessing how employees actively adapt to AI-driven transformations and finding their value in the process. Second, by examining occupational identity crafting from the perspective of AI identity shifts, we contribute to a deeper understanding of individual identity construction. This sheds light on the role of human agency in navigating AI-induced changes. Finally, by testing the moderating effects of different human–AI relationship cognitions, we offer valuable insights into the boundary conditions. These findings provide practical recommendations for organizational management practices.

1. Theoretical grounding and hypotheses development

1.1. Identity work theory in the age of AI

The integration of AI within organizational structures is fundamentally altering the character of work. AI systems are no longer limited to auxiliary or supportive identities; they are increasingly involved in decision-making, performance assessment, and operational management—areas that have historically depended on human expertise (Parker & Grote, 2022). This technological advancement affects not only work processes and task arrangements but also the symbolic underpinnings of occupational identity—specifically, employees’ self-perceptions regarding their roles, contributions, and significance within the workplace (Brown, 2015; Caza, 2018). In this changing environment, identity becomes a focal point not only of disruption but also of agency and reconstruction. Consequently, employees must actively seek to redefine their occupational self-concepts. We term this process occupational identity crafting: a proactive and agentic form of identity work through which individuals reshape their self-perceptions and desired recognition within AI-integrated systems (Caza et al., 2018).

Previous research has established a robust framework of crafting behaviors, such as job crafting (Tims et al., 2012; Wrzesniewski and Dutton, 2001), role crafting (Bruning and Campion, 2018; Kooij et al., 2017), and professional identity formation (Ibarra, 1999). However, these perspectives often fail to fully address how employees manage occupational identity challenges in the context of technological disruption. As detailed in Table 1, existing frameworks tend to focus on changes in job content—that is, adjustments in what employees do and how they do it—while frequently neglecting the deeper, identity-level work through which individuals reconstruct who they are in their occupations. Such occupational identity crafting becomes particularly salient in AI-driven contexts, where employees must reclaim meaning, express values, and pursue development amidst displacement and uncertainty.

Table 1
Overview of prior studies on crafting frameworks and this study.

Topic	Dimensions	Implications	Limitations	References
Job Crafting	Cognitive crafting Task crafting Relational crafting	Highlights how individuals proactively reshape their work by changing tasks, relationships, and perceptions, laying the groundwork for understanding identity work in jobs.	Lacks explicit focus on identity transformation; cognitive changes are abstract and hard to measure separately from task or relational changes.	Wrzesniewski and Dutton (2001)
Job Crafting (JD-R based)	Increasing structural job resources Increasing social job resources Increasingly challenging job demands Decreasing hindering job demands	Emphasizes proactive adjustment of job resources and demands; supports skill development and task expansion perspectives.	Focuses more on stress coping than identity change; does not account for role or self-concept restructuring.	Tims et al. (2012)
Role Crafting	Crafting toward strengths Crafting toward interests	Shows employees’ ability to align roles with personal preferences, supporting the idea that role crafting is identity-relevant.	Limited to motivational aspects (strength/interest); lacks integration with task or skill restructuring processes.	Kooij et al. (2017)
Role Crafting (Approach–Avoidance)	Approach role crafting Avoidance role crafting	Differentiates proactive role expansion from role minimization; useful for understanding dynamic identity negotiation in evolving job environments.	Role orientation is emphasized; however, skill adaptation and task specificity are underdeveloped.	Bruning et al. (2018)
Professional Identities Formation	Identity elements: styles, skills, attitudes, routines.	Provides a foundational view of identity as constructed through experimenting with new roles and skills, justifying the inclusion of “role” and “skill” crafting in identity development.	Conceptual model with limited empirical validation; does not explicitly address task-level actions.	Ibarra (1999)
Occupational Identity Crafting (Identity Work Theory)	Role crafting (identity claiming) Task crafting (identity expression) Skill crafting (identity development)	Highlights how employees reconstruct who they are in relation to their work when collaborating with AI; extends identity work theory to the context of human–AI workplaces.	The model does not yet incorporate other contextual variations across occupations, and the empirical evidence is currently limited to specific experimental tasks.	This study

To address this gap, we utilize identity work theory (Ashforth and Schinoff, 2016; Watson, 2008), which conceptualizes identity construction as an ongoing process through which individuals seek to form, maintain, and revise their identities in response to contextual demands. This process typically involves three interrelated components: Identity claiming, where individuals seek recognition and validation of their identities by negotiating roles and meanings (Ibarra & Barbulescu, 2010); Identity expression, where individuals perform tasks to reveal their identities to others (Collinson, 2003); and Identity development, where individuals invest in acquiring new skills and experiences to support a desired identity (Ibarra, 1999; Petriglieri and Petriglieri, 2010). Building on this foundation, we propose that occupational identity crafting in human–AI workplaces should also incorporate specific crafting content: role crafting, task crafting, and skill crafting (see Fig. 1) across the three components of identity work to redefine who they are.

Role crafting embodies claiming one's identity. It involves the redefinition of one's professional role in symbolic and relational terms to assert a socially recognized occupational identity. For instance, individuals may reposition themselves as human–AI integrators, ethical guardians, or interpreters of algorithmic outputs. These role claims seek validation from colleagues, supervisors, and the broader organization, reinforcing a sense of relevance and legitimacy (Sveningsson & Alvesson, 2003).

Task crafting reflects identity expression. It involves modifying the content of daily work tasks, focus, or sequence to emphasize facets of one's occupational identity. As AI takes over structured or rule-based tasks, employees emphasize distinctive tasks, such as coordination, empathy, and integrative thinking, to redefine the substance of meaningful work (Perez et al., 2024).

Skill crafting captures identity development. It involves the deliberate acquisition, improvement, or re-evaluation of skills to build a future-oriented self-perception. This includes both technical proficiencies, such as AI literacy and data analytics (Pan et al., 2025), and adaptive learning capabilities. These developmental endeavors are not solely functional; they support identity growth by enabling individuals to project a cohesive and aspirational sense of their future selves.

The three dimensions collectively constitute a holistic model of occupational identity crafting, with each dimension addressing a unique identity challenge presented by AI-driven transformations. Crucially, this crafting is not solely a response to external forces; rather, it is a proactive and agentic process of self-construction, enabling individuals to shape both their work practices and their sense of significance.

1.2. Impact of AI identity on employee occupational identity crafting

As AI increasingly integrates into organizations and assumes various identities, employees' occupational self-concepts may be disrupted, making occupational identity crafting a salient response. Different AI identities—assistant, partner, and leader—vary in the extent to which

they reshape social and task boundaries, status signals, and control relations. When AI is framed as a leader, it conveys stronger authority (Kirkman et al., 2009), more explicit status prescriptions (Lei & Rau, 2021), and greater task-allocation power than when it is framed as a partner or assistant. Such leader framing challenges employees' role expectations and occupational self-definitions more sharply, thereby heightening identity salience and producing larger identity gaps.

According to identity work theory, individuals reconstruct their occupational self-concept when identities are disrupted to restore coherence and meaning, and more salient disruptions trigger more intensive identity work. In this context, employees interacting with a leader-framed AI are more likely to: (1) engage in role crafting to renegotiate role boundaries and assert professional status (Lovaglia, 1995); (2) pursue task crafting to preserve or highlight valued aspects of their work and express core occupational values (Song et al., 2022); and (3) undertake skill crafting to develop competencies that reestablish perceptions of competence, relevance, and control (Fong et al., 2002). These identity work practices enable employees to reestablish a coherent occupational self in the face of altered social relations and task structures introduced by AI leadership cues. Accordingly, we propose the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1. *Compared to AI as a partner or assistant, AI framed as a leader will have a stronger impact on employees' occupational identity crafting processes, including a) role crafting, b) task crafting, and c) skill crafting.*

1.3. Moderating role of human–AI relationship cognition

Although AI identity (assistant, partner, and leader) can influence employees' occupational identity crafting, these effects are not uniform across individuals. Whether employees respond proactively depends on their underlying cognitive orientations toward AI (Maedche et al., 2019). Some may see AI as a supportive collaborator that enhances their work, while others may perceive it as a potential replacement that threatens their job. These orientations—known as human–AI relationship cognitions—represent evaluative frames shaped by prior experiences and expectations of AI technologies, capturing whether individuals believe AI primarily substitutes for or augments human capabilities (Raisch and Krakowski, 2021; Tschang and Almirall, 2021).

The threat–opportunity framework (Dutton & Jackson, 1987) provides a useful lens to understand these divergent reactions. This framework suggests that individuals evaluate environmental changes by categorizing them either as threats, which signal the potential loss of valued resources, or as opportunities, which highlight potential gains and growth. Prior studies have shown that when changes are appraised as threats, individuals tend to adopt defensive or avoidant responses that minimize further loss of valued resources (Jackson and Dutton, 1988; Staw et al., 1981). Conversely, when changes are seen as opportunities, individuals are more likely to engage in proactive and constructive behaviors that maximize potential benefits (Shepherd & Williams, 2018).

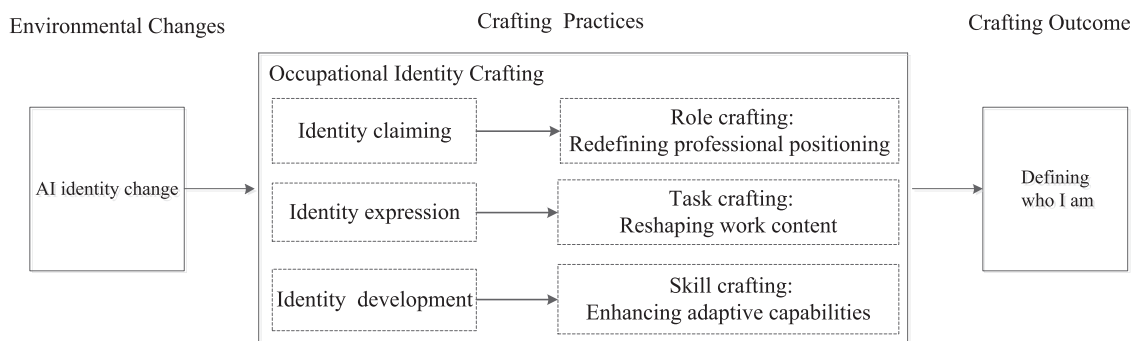


Fig. 1. Occupational identity crafting model.

Building on this logic, we conceptualize substitution and augmentation cognitions as interpretive lenses that shape whether AI identity shifts are experienced as identity threats or opportunities.

When employees hold a substitution cognition, they anticipate that AI will replace human contributions (Lichtenthaler, 2018), which reflects a threat appraisal. Such appraisal heightens feelings of stress and job insecurity, undermines perceptions of autonomy and control, and reduces motivation to engage in proactive identity crafting (Dillion et al., 2023). As AI takes on a more central identity—from assistant to partner to leader—employees with substitution cognition experience increased disruption to their occupational self-concept, although they are less inclined to engage in constructive identity work. Instead, they may reduce role crafting to protect themselves from any further loss of status, disengage from task crafting because of diminished control, and neglect skill crafting because they question its long-term value.

By contrast, when employees hold an augmentation cognition, they view AI as complementing rather than replacing human capabilities, which reflects an opportunity appraisal (Malone, 2018; Wang et al., 2022). Under this orientation, AI leadership is interpreted not as a form of domination but as a catalyst for development and collaboration. Research has shown that opportunity appraisals stimulate proactive adaptation, learning, and resource investment (Tuckey et al., 2012). Accordingly, as AI takes on a more central identity, employees with augmentation cognition are motivated to reassert and renegotiate valued roles through role crafting, redesign tasks to express occupational values in collaboration with AI (Miller, 2018), and invest in skill crafting to sustain relevance and expand competence (Agnes, 2022; Wang and Lu, 2024). Based on the analysis of substitution and augmentation cognition in human–AI relationships, we propose the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 2. *Human–AI relationship cognitions moderate the relationship between AI identity (assistant, partner, and leader) and occupational identity crafting. Specifically, when employees hold an augmentation cognition, the positive effects of AI framed as a leader on (a) role crafting, (b) task crafting, and (c) skill crafting will be more significant than when they hold a substitution cognition.*

1.4. Overview of studies

We investigated our hypotheses using two pre-registered studies. The first study employed a within-subjects design to examine the main effects of AI identity (as an assistant, partner, or leader) on employees' occupational identity crafting. The second study used a between-subjects design to explore the boundary conditions of human–AI relationship cognition. This study provides insights into when different AI identities influence individual occupational identity crafting.

2. Study 1

Study 1 examined whether the AI identity (assistant, partner, and leader) influences employee occupational identity crafting. We recruited workers and instructed them to collaborate with different AI identities (assistant, partner, and leader). We predict that leader AI will be more helpful in improving employee occupational identity crafting. Following this study, we performed an exploratory analysis. This involved interviewing the participants to validate the AI identity (assistant, partner, and leader) and to evaluate their reflections on their work.

2.1. Methods

2.1.1. Participants

According to calculations using G*Power (Faul et al., 2007), for a medium to slightly below medium effect size ($f = 0.25$), a sample size of 53 participants per experiment is required to achieve a statistical power of $1 - \beta = 0.8$. We planned to recruit 25 % more participants than the

calculated sample size to ensure sufficient data. In Study 1, we aimed to recruit 67 participants. Ultimately, 67 participants were included in the study ($M_{age} = 24.88$, $SD = 2.36$; 37 females and 30 males). All participants provided informed consent before participating in the study.

2.1.2. Procedure and materials

Participants were instructed to work with three AIs (assistant, partner, and leader) to design three posters for a “sports drink” product. The assistant AI provided design elements (e.g., color schemes, image libraries), but did not engage in any creative ideation or design decisions, leaving the entire creative process to the participants. The partner AI provided initial design templates and creative suggestions, followed by interactive dialogue, inquiry responses, suggestion adjustments, and collaborative refinement of ideas throughout the design process. The leader AI provided high-level creative conceptual directions and design feedback, taking a more authoritative stance. Participants were responsible for executing the AI's instructions, which positioned the AI as a supervisor. The AI platforms with the three different identities are shown in Fig. 2. To eliminate the influence of differences in operational proficiency, we provided standardized training and operational walk-throughs to all participants before the experiment, ensuring they were proficient in using all three AI platforms.

The experimental process consisted of three stages. First, participants completed the design task with the assistant AI and then filled out the occupational identity crafting scale. Second, they performed the design task with the partner AI, followed by completing the occupational identity crafting scale again. Finally, participants collaborated with the leader AI and completed the scale a third time. Each task was separated by a 2-hour break to reduce task fatigue and carryover effects.

After completing all tasks, the participants were interviewed to assess their experiences across the three AI collaborations. They were asked to rate each task and validate the effectiveness of AI identity and its impact on their work (see Appendix 2).

2.1.3. Measures

We conceptualized that occupational identity crafting in this study comprises three components: role, task, and skill crafting. Participants responded using a Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). We measured role crafting using a four-item scale, adapted from Bruning and Campion (2018) and Qin et al. (2019), and modified it to incorporate the context of AI applications, thereby aligning with the study's objectives. This scale demonstrated high reliability (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.901$). We measured task crafting using a four-item scale adapted from Slemp and Vella-Brodrick (2014) and Song et al. (2022). This scale exhibited excellent reliability (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.922$). Skill crafting was assessed using a four-item scale based on Karasek (1979), modified to the study's focus. This scale demonstrated high reliability (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.888$). To validate the questionnaire, we conducted an exploratory factor analysis. The results indicated a KMO value greater than 0.7, with all item loadings exceeding 0.5 (see Appendix 1), confirming the questionnaire's validity and reliability.

2.2. Results

2.2.1. Testing of Hypothesis 1

We conducted a repeated-measures ANOVA and paired-sample t -tests to examine role, task, and skill crafting. Fig. 3 illustrates the impact of the three distinct AI identities on role, task, and skill crafting. As Fig. 3 shows, role, task, and skill crafting increased as the AI's identity changed, providing preliminary support for Hypothesis 1.

For role crafting, we found significant differences among the assistant AI ($M = 2.07$, $SD = 0.60$), partner AI ($M = 3.62$, $SD = 0.64$), and leader AI ($M = 3.81$, $SD = 0.74$), $F(2, 132) = 129.16$, $\eta^2 = 0.66$. Paired-sample t -tests revealed that role crafting in the leader AI was significantly greater than that in the assistant AI, $t(132) = 13.77$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 2.89$, but not significantly higher than that in the partner

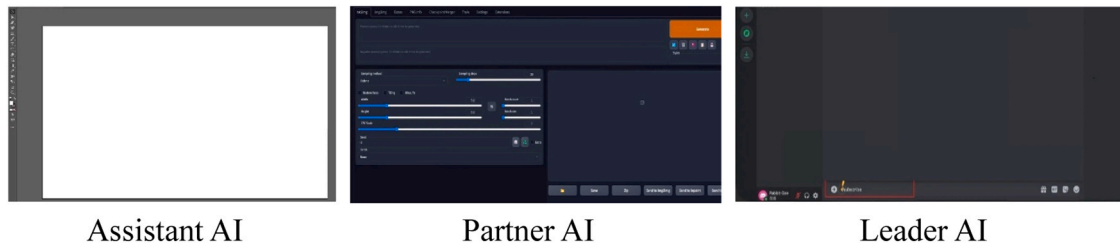


Fig. 2. Three different AI identities.

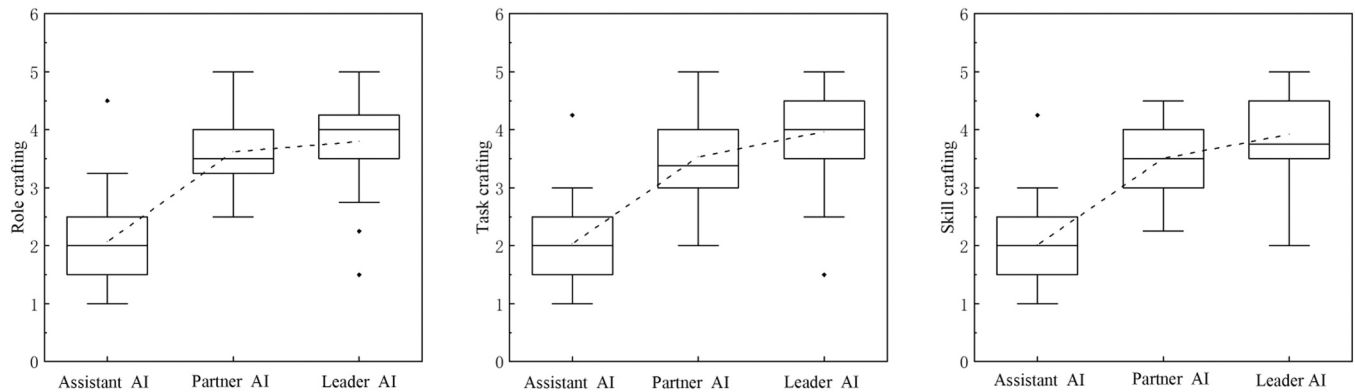


Fig. 3. Impact of different AI identities on individual occupational identity crafting. Notes. The dots in the diagram represent the value of outliers; the dashed line links the mean values.

AI, $t(132) = 1.66$, $p = 0.30$, Cohen's $d = 0.32$. These findings suggest an initial increasing trend, followed by a slowdown in role crafting as AI framed as a leader.

For task crafting, we observed significant differences when participants collaborated with the assistant AI ($M = 2.02$, $SD = 0.58$), partner AI ($M = 3.52$, $SD = 0.72$), and leader AI ($M = 3.98$, $SD = 0.73$), $F(2, 132) = 158.57$, $\eta^2 = 0.71$. Paired-sample t -tests revealed that task crafting in the leader AI was significantly greater than that in the partner AI, $t(132) = 3.70$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.80$, and the assistant AI, $t(132) = 17.34$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 3.39$. These results indicate that the likelihood of task crafting increases as AI framed as a leader.

Similarly, for skill crafting, significant differences were also found between the assistant AI ($M = 2.00$, $SD = 0.60$), partner AI ($M = 3.50$, $SD = 0.55$), and leader AI ($M = 3.90$, $SD = 0.66$), $F(2, 132) = 188.00$, $\eta^2 = 0.74$. Paired-sample t -tests indicated that skill crafting in the leader AI was significantly greater than that in the partner AI, $t(132) = 3.95$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.66$, and the assistant AI, $t(132) = 17.75$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 3.16$. Thus, the likelihood of skill crafting increases as AI is framed as a leader.

2.3. Discussion

Study 1 employed a relatively simple within-subject design of working adults from various organizations. The results indicate that when AI is framed as a leader, individuals are more likely to perform role, task, and skill crafting, providing initial support for Hypothesis 1. Additionally, we made an interesting observation: the rate of role crafting slows as AI identity shifts. This deceleration may have been due to the need for an adjustment period (Black & Ashford, 1995). As task and skill crafting increases, individuals gradually acquire new skills and knowledge to adapt to the human-AI work environment (Gardner et al., 2022; Zahhly and Tosi, 1989), stabilizing their new roles. This stabilization may explain the reduced pace of role crafting.

Although Study 1 provides initial evidence for Hypothesis 1, its within-subject design limits comparisons between groups and lacks control over potential confounding variables. Therefore, we designed

Study 2 with improvements and focused on exploring the moderating role of human-AI relationship cognition.

3. Study 2

In Study 2, our objective was to test Hypothesis 1 further using a between-subjects design. Additionally, we investigated the moderating role of human-AI relationship cognition in the link between AI identity (assistant, partner, and leader) and employee occupational identity crafting. Building on Study 1, we recruited new participants and randomly assigned them to one of three groups (group 1: Assistant AI, group 2: Partner AI, group 3: Leader AI). The goal was to examine how participants' human-AI relationship cognitions moderate the relationship between AI identities and occupational identity crafting. We predicted that employees with higher augmentation cognition would exhibit stronger increases in occupational identity crafting in response to AI identity shifts.

3.1. Methods

3.1.1. Participants

Sixty participants were recruited through telephone and email and randomly assigned to work with three AI identities (group 1: Assistant AI, group 2: Partner AI, group 3: Leader AI). We did not allow participants in Study 1 to also take part in Study 2 to ensure that each participant would be bias-free from prior knowledge. Using G*Power for sample size estimation (Faul et al., 2007), we determined that we needed 51 participants (17 per group) to achieve a power of 0.8 at an alpha level of 0.05 to detect a significant effect. Sixty participants were recruited to ensure gender balance. Table 2 presents detailed information on the participants in each group. All participants provided informed consent.

3.1.2. Procedure and materials

In Study 2, the three groups of participants were informed that they were helping a supermarket that needed to design a promotional poster

Table 2
Information about participants in each group.

Group	N	Gender		Age		Work experience	
		Female	Male	Mean	SD	Mean	SD
1. Assistant AI	20	10	10	23.82	2.12	3.21	1.02
2. Partner AI	20	10	10	24.49	2.36	3.49	1.43
3. Leader AI	20	10	10	24.34	2.14	3.57	1.26

for an anniversary event. Their main task was to work with the AI to complete the poster design work and post it online. The poster's number of retweets and likes served as a bonus payoff. As in Study 1, the participants in each group were instructed about the operation of the AI tool before starting the study.

Three groups of participants simultaneously performed a poster design task, which was posted online at the end of the task. They were then asked to rate their roles, tasks, and skills during the poster design process and finally report their understanding of the human–AI relationship. Notably, we did not attempt to manipulate participants' relationship cognition. Instead, we measured their personal beliefs regarding substitution and augmentation cognition following task exposure.

3.1.3. Measures

Occupational Identity Crafting. In line with Study 1, occupational identity crafting in this study comprised three dimensions: role, task, and skill crafting. We measured role crafting using a 4-item scale modified from Bruning and Campion (2018) and Qin et al. (2019), with a Cronbach's α of 0.714. We assessed task crafting using a 4-item scale developed by Slemph and Vella-Brodrick (2014) and Song et al. (2022), which achieved a Cronbach's α of 0.885. Skill crafting was measured using a 4-item scale based on Karasek (1979), yielding a Cronbach's α of 0.793.

Human–AI Relationship Cognition. Given the nascent and abstract nature of human–AI relationship cognition, we initially performed a literature review to synthesize extant research. Recognizing the strong association between organizational AI implementation and the adoption of novel technologies, we adapted measurement items from Majchrzak and Cotton (1988), Herold et al. (1995), Haddad (1996), and Brougham and Haar (2018), which assessed employee attitudes toward automation, robotics, and new technologies. These items were modified to reflect attitudes toward AI applications, while also incorporating contemporary considerations. Subsequently, expert consultation guided the refinement, selection, and categorization of these items, culminating in a preliminary 12-item scale for human–AI relationship cognition, detailed in Appendix 1. This scale comprised seven items assessing human–AI relationship augmentation cognition (Cronbach's α = 0.873), which captured the collaborative execution of tasks between humans and AI, and five items evaluating substitution cognition (Cronbach's α = 0.802), which highlighted AI's assumption of human tasks. Furthermore, to validate the scale's efficacy, we conducted exploratory factor analysis (EFA). The results revealed two components with eigenvalues exceeding 1, accounting for a cumulative variance of 68.63 %. All item loadings surpassed 0.5, indicating that each measurement item converged on the same factor, thereby supporting the scale's structural validity.

3.2. Results

3.2.1. Testing of Hypothesis 1

A one-way ANOVA was conducted to compare role, task, and skill crafting across the three groups (see Table 3). The results showed significant differences in role crafting ($F(2, 57) = 17.97, p < 0.001$), task crafting ($F(2, 57) = 45.20, p < 0.001$), and skill crafting ($F(2, 57) = 37.49, p < 0.001$) among the groups. Further post hoc comparisons (Tukey) revealed that the leader AI group showed significantly higher

Table 3
Comparison of occupational identity crafting results among different groups.

Predictors	M $\pm$ SD			F	P	Tukey
	1. Assistant AI	2. Partner AI	3. Leader AI			
Role	2.41	3.21	3.48	17.97	< .001	1 < 2, 1 < 3
crafting	± 0.65	± 0.50	± 0.60			
Task	2.20	3.44	3.93	45.20	< .001	1 < 2 < 3
crafting	± 0.65	± 0.62	± 0.49			
Skill	2.29	3.20	3.68	37.49	< .001	1 < 2 < 3
crafting	± 0.44	± 0.57	± 0.53			

levels of task and skill crafting compared with the partner and assistant AI groups. However, we found no significant difference between the leader and partner AI groups in role crafting. These findings are consistent with the results of Study 1, indicating that, as AI identity shifts from assistant to leader, the rate of role crafting tends to decelerate.

3.2.2. Testing of Hypothesis 2

As shown in Table 4, the confirmatory factor analysis results showed that the 5-factor model fitted best ($\chi^2 = 318.439, df = 236, RMSEA = 0.046, CFI = 0.920, TLI = 0.983$), significantly outperforming the other competing models. Based on these results, we conclude that our 5-factor model had good discriminant validity.

As Table 5 shows, augmentation cognition positively correlated with role ($r = 0.63, p < 0.01$), task ($r = 0.74, p < 0.01$), and skill crafting ($r = 0.71, p < 0.01$). Substitution cognition was negatively correlated with task ($r = -0.39, p < 0.01$) and skill crafting ($r = -0.37, p < 0.01$).

To clarify the moderating effect, we used regression analysis to examine how different human–AI relationship cognitions moderate the relationship between AI identities (assistant, partner, and leader) and occupational identity crafting. AI identity was considered as a categorical variable with the assistant AI as the comparison group.

Employees reported significantly higher role crafting under partner AI ($\beta = 0.51, p < 0.01$) and leader AI ($\beta = 0.58, p < 0.001$) compared to assistant AI. Moderation analysis revealed that the interaction terms of substitution cognition with partner and leader AI were not significant. However, the interaction terms between augmentation cognition and partner AI ($\beta = 0.63, p < 0.05$) and leader AI ($\beta = 0.65, p < 0.05$) were significant. Fig. 4 shows that participants with higher augmentation cognition exhibited stronger role crafting when AI was framed as a leader. Thus, augmentation cognition positively moderated the relationship between leader AI and role crafting, whereas substitution cognition did not show a significant moderating effect. Therefore, H2a is partially supported.

Similar patterns were observed for task crafting. Both partner AI ($\beta = 0.78, p < 0.01$) and leader AI ($\beta = 0.99, p < 0.001$) significantly increased task crafting compared to assistant AI. Regarding moderation, the interaction terms of substitution cognition with partner AI and leader AI were not significant. In contrast, the interaction effect of partner AI and augmentation cognition on task crafting was significant ($\beta = 1.12, p < 0.001$), as was the interaction effect of leader AI and augmentation cognition on task crafting ($\beta = 0.66, p < 0.05$). As shown in Fig. 4, the effect of AI framed as a leader on task crafting was stronger among participants with higher augmentation cognition. Therefore, augmentation cognition exhibits a positive moderating effect, and H2b is partially supported.

For skill crafting, both partner AI ($\beta = 0.56, p < 0.01$) and leader AI ($\beta = 0.82, p < 0.001$) groups showed higher levels compared to assistant AI. Moderation analyses revealed the interaction terms of substitution cognition with partner AI and leader AI were not significant. However, augmentation cognition significantly moderated the effect of both partner AI ($\beta = 0.48, p < 0.05$) and leader AI ($\beta = 0.57, p < 0.05$) on skill crafting. Fig. 4 further illustrates that when AI identities shift from

Table 4
Multilevel confirmatory factor analysis results.

MODEL	χ^2	df	CFI	TLI	RMSEA	SRMR
One-factor model (AC+SC+RC+TC+SC)	506.117	252	0.692	0.663	0.130	0.104
Two-factor model (AC+SC, RC+TC+SC)	498.747	251	0.700	0.670	0.128	0.104
Three-factor model (AC+SC, RC, TC+SC)	487.781	249	0.710	0.679	0.126	0.105
Four-factor model (AC+SC, RC, TC, SC)	476.459	246	0.721	0.687	0.125	0.106
Five-factor model (AC, SC, RC, TC, SC)	318.439	236	0.920	0.983	0.046	0.064

Note. AC = augmentation cognition; SC = substitution cognition; RC = role crafting; TC = task crafting; SC = skill crafting.

Table 5
Descriptive statistics and relations.

Variables	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4
1. Augmentation cognition	3.34	0.65				
2. Substitution cognition	2.67	0.67	−0.21			
3. Role crafting	3.03	0.73	0.63**	−0.21		
4. Task crafting	3.19	0.93	0.74**	−0.39**	0.65**	
5. Skill crafting	3.05	0.77	0.71**	−0.37**	0.62**	0.73**

Note. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$.

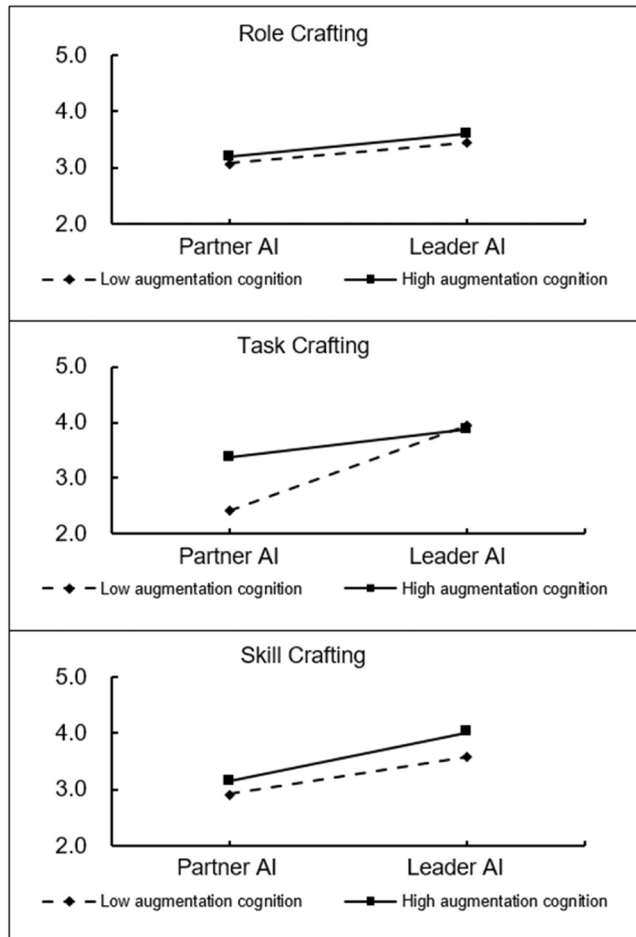


Fig. 4. Moderating effect of augmentation cognition. Note. Assistant AI is used as a comparison group.

partner to leader, the moderating effect of augmentation cognition on skill crafting becomes more pronounced. Hence, H2c is also partially supported.

3.3. Discussion

Using a between-subjects design, Study 2 confirmed the main effects and provided support for the moderating role of augmentation cognition, whereas substitution cognition did not show a significant moderation effect. This pattern may be due to substitution cognition reflecting a stable disengaged stance, producing a floor effect in crafting behaviors (i.e., uniformly low levels regardless of AI framing). Nonetheless, these findings highlight the critical role of employees' cognitive framing of AI's presence. This result aligns with [Dang and Liu \(2022\)](#), who demonstrated that a positive mindset facilitates individuals' adaptation to changes in the work environment when confronted with AI-related challenges. Moreover, these findings have practical implications for individual development, suggesting that employees who view AI as an opportunity are better positioned to reassess and reconstruct their occupational identities and to flexibly adapt to emerging work patterns by complementing AI.

4. General discussion

This study explored whether AI identity (from assistant to partner to leader) influenced occupational identity crafting among organizational employees. Drawing on the threat–opportunity framework, the study examined the moderating role of human–AI relationship cognition in this process. Across two pre-registered experiments, we found that leader AI triggers more significant task, skill, and role crafting compared to assistant and partner AI (Study 1). Moreover, the positive effect of AI framed as a leader on these three dimensions of occupational identity crafting was stronger among participants with higher levels of augmentation cognition (Study 2). Our findings broadly suggest that, as AI becomes more prevalent in organizations and assumes new identities, employees must proactively craft their occupational identity to maintain their unique value and importance. Only those who adapt to these changes will maintain long-term competitiveness.

4.1. Contributions to theory

This study makes several theoretical contributions to the literature. First, previous research on AI identity focused primarily on responsibility attribution and the relative status of humans and AI ([Jago et al., 2024](#); [Lei and Rau, 2021](#)). This study expands this research by examining employee occupational identity crafting in response to AI identity (assistant, partner, and leader). Moreover, in the limited literature on occupational identity crafting in the AI era, most studies have emphasized that employees must accept technological change under organizational pressure, focusing on the negative effects of AI on employees. Conversely, this study highlights employees' autonomy and adaptability ([Ghitulescu, 2013](#)), emphasizing the extent to which AI identity influences their occupational identity crafting.

Second, this study operationalizes employee occupational identity crafting through three dimensions based on identity work theory: role, task, and skill. While prior research has underscored the importance of occupational identity, a dimensional framework and empirical measures that detail the behavioral crafting of this occupational identity are absent ([Kira and Balkin, 2014](#); [Murphy and Kreiner, 2020](#)). Consequently,

this research establishes a foundation for further investigation into occupational identity crafting and provides direction on how employees refine their professional identity. Additionally, the findings reveal a slowing trend in role crafting as AI identity shifts. [Jarrahi \(2019\)](#) offers a potential explanation: as AI assumes more organizational responsibilities, employee role boundaries become clearer. This clarity reduces role ambiguity and diminishes the need for employees to redefine or adjust their roles ([Huang & Rust, 2018](#)). Building on these findings, we suggest that, as task and skill crafting increase, employees’ understanding of their roles stabilizes, leading to a deceleration in role crafting. Overall, this study expands research on occupational identity crafting in the AI era.

Finally, based on the threat–opportunity framework, this study conceptualized human–AI relationship cognitions—augmentation and substitution—as individual interpretive lenses that shape how employees respond to AI identity. Our results show that augmentation cognition moderates the relationship between AI identity and role, task, and skill crafting, whereas substitution cognition does not exhibit a significant moderating effect. While prior research has emphasized that crafting behavior is primarily driven by external environmental cues ([Cloutier and Ravasi, 2020](#); [Gioia et al., 2013](#)), our findings highlight the boundary role of augmentation cognition in shaping employees’ proactive occupational identity crafting. Specifically, employees with higher augmentation cognition are more likely to leverage AI identity shifts as opportunities to engage in role, task, and skill crafting. This study thus advances our understanding of AI’s function in the workplace and identifies that employees with supportive cognitive orientations adapt more effectively to AI integration.

4.2. Contributions to practice

From a practical perspective, as organizations increasingly integrate AI into various work functions, it is vital to consider the implications for employees. This study reveals that in response to the challenges posed by AI, employees can redefine “who they are” and establish their occupational identities through role, task, and skill crafting. Consequently, employees gain a strategic advantage by enhancing their competencies through occupational identity crafting behaviors. Therefore, we recommend that employees in human–AI collaborative environments proactively adapt to changes in work characteristics or contexts, leveraging transition periods as opportunities to build value through intentional occupational identity crafting. Additionally, research demonstrates that fostering constructive human–AI relationship augmentation cognition among employees can support effective occupational identity crafting in response to AI identity ([Wu et al., 2024](#)). Thus, organizations implementing AI should prioritize cultivating positive human–AI relationship cognition in their workforce. For example, managers can address employees’ psychological needs in human–AI collaborations by providing timely support and communication to alleviate potential negative emotions ([Lam & Lau, 2012](#)).

4.3. Limitations and future directions

This study has limitations. First, in Study 1, we adopted a within-

subjects design to examine occupational identity crafting across different AI identities. This design may be subject to potential order effects, as the sequence of exposure to various AI identities could have influenced participants’ responses. Although Study 2 employed a between-subjects design that eliminated such concerns and yielded consistent results, future research should explicitly test both forward and reverse sequences to capture potential order effects more rigorously. Second, this study examined occupational identity crafting in the context of poster design tasks. Recognizing that different jobs may affect occupational identity crafting differently, future research should explore the process of occupational identity crafting in different jobs through a contextual comparative analysis. Finally, we document that augmentation cognition strengthens the positive effect of AI identity (assistant, partner, and leader) on employees’ occupational identity crafting. However, our study did not probe the internal mechanisms—the “black box”—through which AI identities exert their influence on occupational identity crafting. Therefore, future research should aim to analyze these causal pathways, for example by examining whether perceptions of control and autonomy mediate the relationship between AI identity and employees’ occupational identity crafting.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Chen Zhen: Visualization, Methodology, Data curation. **Niu Lixia:** Supervision, Funding acquisition. **Wang Shiquan:** Resources, Investigation. **Zhao Rui:** Writing – original draft, Investigation, Conceptualization.

Ethical compliance

The research complies with ethical standards and necessary approvals were obtained.

Authorship

All authors listed have contributed significantly to the research and agree with the content.

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Originality

The manuscript is my (our) original work and has not been published elsewhere.

Declaration of Competing Interest

There are no conflicts of interest, or any potential conflicts will be disclosed.

Appendix 1. Survey Instrument

Construct	Measuring items	EFA Factor loading
Task crafting	I introduce new approaches to improve my work when working with AI.	0.748
	I change the scope or type of tasks when working with AI.	0.630
	I choose to take on additional tasks when working with AI.	0.675
	I engage in tasks that require ethical reasoning or human judgment when working with AI.	0.643
Skill crafting	My job skill level has been high since the organization introduced AI.	0.708

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(continued)

Role crafting	I need to learn new things after organizations introduce AI.	0.721
	My nonrepetitious work is high after the organization introduces AI.	0.716
	I will need to be more creative after the organization introduces AI.	0.800
	Working with AI, I need to reassess my roles and responsibilities.	0.780
	Working with AI, I went from a job controller to a job facilitator.	0.811
Augmentation cognition	I am willing to accept this shift in my work role.	0.717
	I can adjust my work to fit the new role proactively.	0.724
	AI has improved the way I work.	0.847
	AI has reduced my workload.	0.727
	AI frees me from procedural work.	0.555
	AI improves my work efficiency.	0.789
	AI improves the quality of my work.	0.830
Substitution cognition	AI allows me to do more valuable work.	0.696
	I like the adoption of AI in my organization.	0.756
	I feel more stressed on the job since the AI was adopted.	0.642
	AI will reduce my work status.	0.703
	AI is a threat to my work security.	0.868
	I would be concerned about my future.	0.748
	I want to go back to my job the way it was before AI was adopted.	0.755

Appendix 2. Interview Content

- 1. Did you enjoy the process of working with the AI?
- 2. How would you rate the level of intelligence of the three AIs with which you worked?
- 3. Were you able to perceive the different identities played by the different AIs in your work?
- 4. How do you feel that your work changed during these three tasks?
- 5. Were you able to accept such a change in your work?

Data Availability

Data will be made available on request.

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